

flea

NEWS65

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<http://www.entsoc.org/networks/Interest/fleanews.htm>

FLEA NEWS is a biannual newsletter about fleas (Siphonaptera). It is mainly bibliographic in nature, but recipients are urged to check any citations given here before including them in publications. Many of our sources are abstracting journals and current literature sources such as National Agricultural Library (NAL) Agricola, and National Library of Medicine (NLM) Medline, and citations have not necessarily been checked for accuracy or consistent formatting.

Recipients are urged to contribute items of interest to the profession for inclusion herein, including: Flea research citations from journals that are not indexed in Agricola or Medline databases, Announcements and Requests for material, Contact information for a Directory of Siphonapterists (name, mailing address, email address, and areas of interest - Systematics, Ecology, Control, etc.), Abstracts of research planned or in progress, Book reviews, Biography, Hypotheses and Literature Reviews, and Anecdotes. Send to:

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Announcements

Two papers on fleas were presented at the 57th Annual Meeting of the Entomological Society of America, December 13-16, 2009, Indianapolis Convention Center, Indianapolis, Indiana:

"An overview of the development of Comfortis (spinosad) as an oral systemic insecticide to control fleas on dogs." Daniel E. Snyder, Elanco Animal Health, Greenfield, IN.

"Cat flea larvae (*Ctenocephalides felis*) are disrupted by stray electromagnetic fields emanating from appliances." Thomas Dykstra, Dykstra Laboratories, Inc., Gainesville, FL.

A couple of papers were presented at the 5th International Congress of Vector Ecology in Antalya, Turkey, October 11-16, 2009, that involved fleas. Mosquitoes and, to a lesser extent, ticks pretty much dominated the meeting:

"Fleas as Vectors for *Bartonella* Species." Richard Birtles (richard.birtles@liverpool.ac.uk), Faculty of Veterinary Sciences, University of Liverpool, UK.

"Research of Vectors of *Bartonella* in China." Qiyong Liu (liuqiyong@icdc.cn), Department of Vector Biology and Control, National Institute for Communicable Diseases Control and Prevention, China CDC, Beijing, China.

New books on medical entomology

Prevention of Bug Bites, Stings, and Disease.

2009. Daniel Strickman, Stephen P. Frances and Mustapha Debboun. (Daniel A. Strickman, Veterinary, Medical, and Urban Entomology, USDA, Agricultural Research Service), 352 pp., 48 halftone & 77 line illus., 978-0-19-536577-1 cloth \$74.00, 978-0-19-536578-8 paper \$19.95.

Veterinary Entomology: Livestock and Companion Animals.

2009. Ralph E. Williams (Purdue University, West Lafayette, Indiana, USA). 375 pp., ISBN: 9781420068498, ISBN 10: 1420068490, CRC Press Cat. #: 68490, \$99.95.

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Meetings

The Annual Meeting of the Eastern Branch of the Entomological Society of America will be held in Annapolis, Maryland, March 7-9, 2010.

URL: <http://www.ebesa.ento.vt.edu/index.html>

The Annual Meeting of the North Central Branch of the Entomological Society of America will be held March 14-17, 2010 at the Brown Hotel in Louisville, Kentucky.

A Joint Annual Meeting between the Southwestern Branch of the Entomological Society of America and the Mexican Entomological Society will be held at the Hilton Hotel in Cancun, Mexico, April 11- 17, 2010.

URL: <http://swbesa.tamu.edu>.

Joint IOBC - Nearctic and Neotropic Regional Sections Conference: Biocontrol in the Americas - Past, Present and Future, May 11-13, 2010 at the Sheraton Fallsview Hotel and Conference Centre in Niagara Falls, Ontario, Canada.

Contact: Les Shipp, Ph.D., 519-738-1235, Les.Shipp@agr.gc.ca or Stefan Jaronski, stefan.jaronski@ars.usda.gov, 406-433-9486.

URL: http://www.iobcnrs.com/event_5-11-10.htm

International Public Health Pesticides Workshop, 19-21 May 2009 London, UK

American Veterinary Medical Association, 147th Annual Convention, July 31 - August 3, 2010. Atlanta.

The 9th European Congress of Entomology will be held August 22-27, 2010 in Budapest, Hungary.

URL: <http://www.nhmus.hu/ECE2010>

Society for Vector Ecology (SOVE) Annual Conference, September 26-30, Raleigh, North Carolina.

The 2010 ESA Annual Meeting will be held December 12-15, 2010, at the Town and Country Hotel and Convention Center in San Diego, California.

Contact: ESA Annual Meeting, 10001 Derekwood Lane, Suite 100, Lanham, MD 20706, phone 301-731-4535, fax 301-731-4538.

Kit fox memories of Harold Egoscue

by Chris Wemmer

Huzzah! We camera trapped our first kit fox (*Vulpes macrotis*). It happened at 3:12 in the morning, one day after the first coyote's passage down the gully. The visit was brief though -- we got only one picture.

There were few burrows in the area, and resident kit foxes usually forage within 3 km of their burrows. Little canids like kit foxes need to steer clear of bigger ones like coyotes, and the best way to do it is not to stray too far from your burrows. If not, coyotes will render a rambling kit fox into dead meat.

Suzie, Harold Egoscue's pet coyote, used to scare the bejeebers out of his captive kit foxes. Egoscue's study of kit foxes at the Dugway Proving Grounds in Utah was the first definitive study of the species. I was lucky to work with him at the National Zoo. We were hired at the same time -- he was nearing the end of his career, and I was starting mine.

The zoo's young zoologists soon realized that the soft spoken ex-Marine Basque-American mammalogist had a great deal more than a technical knowledge of mammals. He was an all-round naturalist who had logged years of field research. He knew a great deal of botany and was a master gardener with a special knack for espalier. He knew soils and geology, archeology, and was a student of Native American crafts. He was a flea systematist, a gifted artist, and had remarkable penmanship.

Ask him about ringtails, and he told you about the pet one he kept for a year, then he would segue into field observations and their habitat associations in Utah. Ask him about badgers or long-tailed weasels, and he had more personal experiences. His accounts were glimpses into the past, with curious twists, often laced with Native American lore. It was like listening to Ernest Thompson Seton. None of us was happy when he announced that he was going to retire.

I wasn't willing to let our relationship end there. So a couple years later, on our annual pilgrimage to the national parks we made our way to his retirement home in Grantsville, Utah. In two fine days I learned why Harold became a naturalist.

He grew up pretty much in the middle of nowhere. At the age of 16 his father, Jean Peter emigrated from France, and from Ellis Island went directly to Winnemucca, Nevada where Basque friends of the family set him up with a wagon and collies tending sheep. If you haven't seen a Basque sheepherder's camp, let me just say it is a pretty basic form of living -- or at least it used to be. As was common at the time, he requested payment in sheep rather than greenback dollars, and he grazed his own animals with the company's stock. In due course he became his own sheepman and a landowner, and married Laura Luce, a schoolteacher in eastern Oregon.

Harold was the first of 4 children. He and his brother Peter spent summers with their father tending sheep, exploring, observing and sketching wildlife, and collecting arrowheads. "I would fill a 2 pound coffee can with arrow heads during the summer, and I traded and gave them all away by the time school let out the next year. Then I'd fill another coffee can."

Harold was 9 years old when his father died, and his mother took over the management of the ranches. Without a father he gravitated to the Sue family, descendants of Chief Winnemucca. His peer, Owen Sue taught him how to kill Townsend ground squirrels with slingshot and bow and arrow, but Harold found that he could earn more money by drowning squirrels out of their burrows with irrigation water. "We sold them to the Indian families for 25 cents apiece. The women would roll the whole squirrel in clayey mud and toss it in the fire, which was an open hearth on the middle of the house. In 15 minutes the squirrel was cooked. The hair and skin came off with the clay, and they flicked the viscera into the fire. Then it was ready to eat." Harold was proof that you can learn a lot in the middle of nowhere.

After 4 years in the Marines, and a bachelors degree at the Utah State University he returned to the basin and range country. His education about things natural was self driven. I only wish he was still around. I still have a lot of questions for him.

Harold's publications on Kit Fox

Egoscue, H.J. 1956. Preliminary studies of the kit fox in Utah. *Journal of Mammalogy*, 37: 351-357.

Egoscue, H.J. 1962. Ecology and life history of the kit fox in Tooele County, Utah. *Ecology*, 43(3): 481-497.

Egoscue, H.J. 1966. Description of a newborn kit fox. *The Southwestern Naturalist*, 11(4): 501-502.

Egoscue, H.J. 1975. Population dynamics of the kit fox in western Utah. *Bulletin of the Southern California Academy of Sciences*, 74(3): 122-127.

He also wrote the Mammalian Species (American Society of Mammalogists) account of the Swift Fox based on a review of the literature:

Egoscue, H.J. 1979. *Vulpes velox*. *Mammalian Species* 122:1-5.

<<http://cameratrappcodger.blogspot.com/2009/12/kit-fox-memories-of-harold-egoscue.html>>
Citation: <<http://cameratrappcodger.blogspot.com>>, accessed December 4, 2009.

Editor's note: Thanks to Chris Wemmer for permitting the use of the previous article. The ringtail is *Bassariscus astutus*, long-tailed weasel *Mustela frenata*, badger *Taxidea taxus*, Townsend ground squirrel *Spermophilus townsendii*. A partial listing of H.J. Egoscue's publications was in *Flea News* 62, June 2008, and additional publications include:

Porter, R.D., and H.J. Egoscue. 1954. The Lark Bunting in Utah. *Wilson Bulletin* 66:219-221.

Egoscue, H.J. 1970. A laboratory colony of the Polynesian rat, *Rattus exulans*. *Journal of Mammalogy* 51: 261-266.

Egoscue, Harold J. and Frank, Elizabeth S. 1984. Burrowing and denning habits of a captive colony of the Utah prairie dog. *Great Basin Naturalist* 44(3): 495-98. - Editor

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Siphonaptera Literature June 2009-December 2009

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